SQUEEZE PLAYS

ABOUT THE DEALS

Feel free to disagree with the bidding; it is only there so as to get to a contract appropriate for some particular squeeze play. In fact, the bidding is irrelevant except in Deals where the opponent's bids may influence your actions.

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. This is to get you started thinking about how you would play the hand.

Having the defender's hands visible at the second page is not a perfect scenario. For example, there will be situations where you, as Declarer, are still playing for a suit to split 3-3 when you only have to peek at the hands to see that the split is 4-2. However, the other possibility of keeping the defender's hands hidden until later would prevent you from seeing how your plays are squeezing them. On balance, we decided to use the more open method.

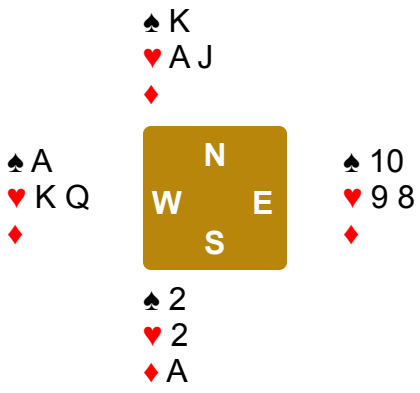
You are always going to be the Declarer, playing in the South position.

You will notice that a large portion of the 20 Deals are slam hands. This is not because Squeezes don't arise in lower contracts, just that the presentation and explanations are less cluttered when there is only one (or none) trick that can be lost.

SQUEEZE PLAYS SUMMARY

The basic principle of a Squeeze Play can be summed up with this statement.

> A DEFENDER CANNOT HOLD ON TO THREE GUARD CARDS WHEN HE HAS ONLY TWO CARDS IN HIS HAND



South is in her hand and she plays the ♦A.

West cannot throw his ♠A because dummy's ♠K would then be high.

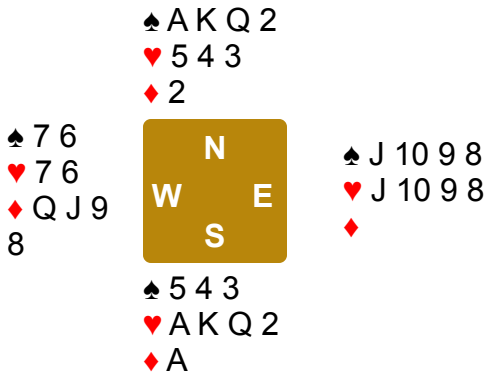
But he also cannot throw his ♥Q because then South would discard dummy's ♠K and win two tricks with ♥A, ♥J.

We say that West is Squeezed in ♠s and ♥s. He needed to keep all three cards at a time when he had to come down to just two.

The statement in the blue box is definitely True, but it isn't complete.
You could also say:
A defender cannot hold four guards when he has only three cards.

Or even:
A defender cannot hold eight guards when he has only seven cards.

You get the idea. Look at an example of the eight and seven situation:



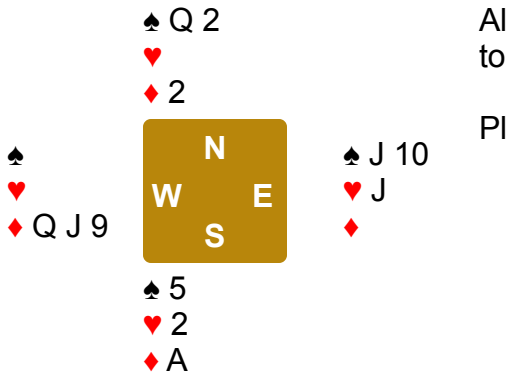
South is in her hand and she plays the ♦A.

East needs to keep all 4 ♠s to stop dummy's ♠2.

But he also must keep all 4 ♥s to stop your ♥2, (though he might not realize the importance of this).

We say that East is Squeezed in ♠s and ♥s. He needed to keep all eight cards at a time when he had to come down to just seven.

Perhaps it is already obvious to you that all those extra winners in each hand don't affect the fundamental squeeze position. Take the last example and play dummy's ♠ A K and then your own ♥ A K Q. You would then have this basic position:



All the extra winners have already been won and you are down to basics.

Play the ♦A and squeeze East in ♠s and ♥s.

There are three terms we use when talking about squeezes.

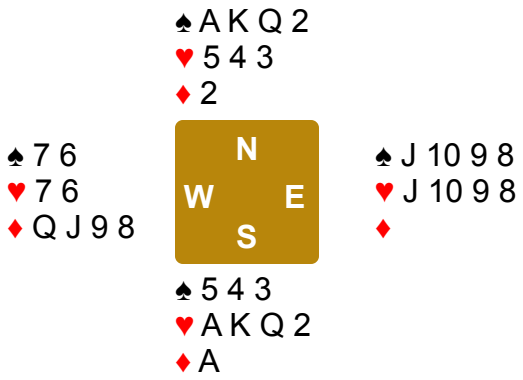
A **THREAT** is a card which is not yet a winner but THREATENS to become a winner if a defender discards a higher card in the suit. In the example above your ♥2 and dummy's ♠2 are both Threats.

A **GUARD** is a card(s) held by a defender that is preventing one of your Threats from becoming a winner. East's ♠ J 10 is a Guard against dummy's ♠2 and East's ♥J is a Guard against your ♥2.

The **SQUEEZE CARD** is the card you play which forces a defender to give up one of his Guards. Here the Squeeze Card was the ♦A.

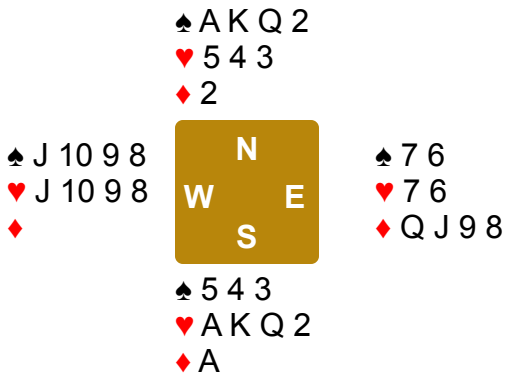
Automatic Squeeze:

Remember this?



South plays the ♦A and **EAST** is Squeezed in ♠s and ♥s.

Suppose the East and West hands were switched:



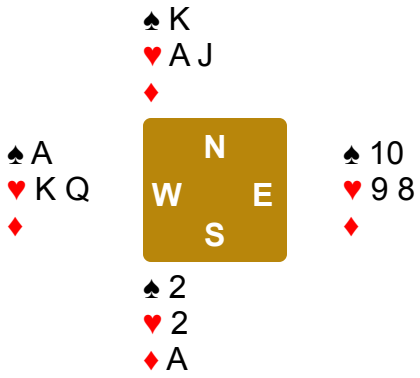
South plays the ♦A and **WEST** is Squeezed in ♠s and ♥s.

An automatic squeeze is just a squeeze which will work equally well against either defender.

Deal 1 shows you a full example of an automatic squeeze. Feel free to go there right now and then come back for the next bit.

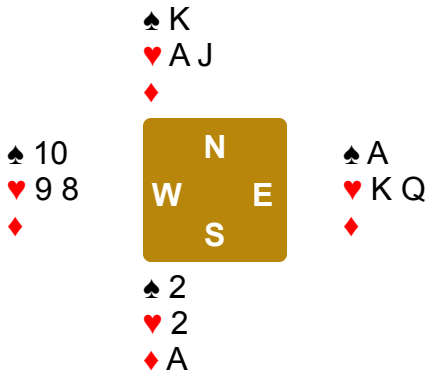
Positional Squeeze:

Remember this?



South plays the ♦A and **WEST** is Squeezed in ♠s and ♥s.

Suppose the East and West hands were switched:



South plays the ♦A and **EAST** is not squeezed at all!
In fact it is dummy that is squeezed. Since dummy has to play before East does, East just watches and discards the same suit as dummy.

This is a Positional Squeeze, so called because it only works on one of the Defenders.

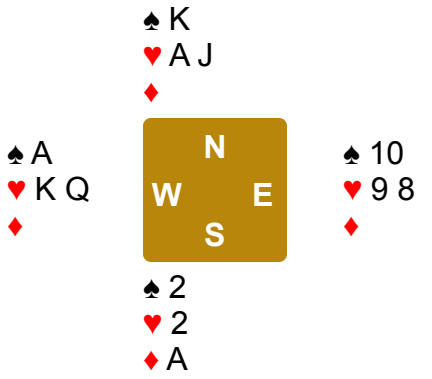
Deal 2 is an example of a positional squeeze. Feel free to go check it out, then come back.

Rectifying the Count:

That may sound rather high-tech but it's not really that bad.

MOST SQUEEZES CAN ONLY OCCUR WHEN
YOU MUST WIN ALL THE REST OF THE TRICKS

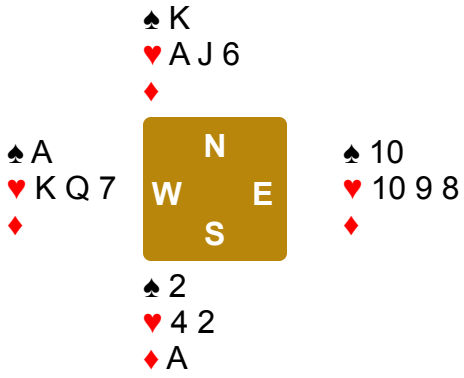
Look at this end position one more time.



South needs to win all the rest of the tricks.

South plays the ♦A and WEST is squeezed in ♠s and ♥s.
He is squeezed because all of his cards are Busy - they are all doing guardwork.

Now give everybody an extra ♥.



South needs to win 3 of the last 4 tricks.

South plays the ♦A and WEST is not squeezed.
He has one card, the ♥7, which is not Busy doing guardwork.
So he just discards that card and awaits his two tricks.

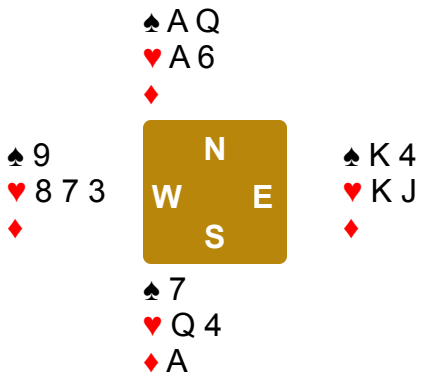
If you checked out Deals 1 and 2 earlier you didn't run across this problem. And for a very good reason - both of those Deals involved Grand Slams so you were already in a spot where you needed the "rest of the tricks".

When you are playing a small slam, though, rectifying the count is vital. So when your Plan calls for a squeeze to be made at the end you will have to give up one trick to the defenders early.

Deal 3 (surprise) just happens to demonstrate rectifying the count. So if you want to see it work in the context of a full deal just check that out and then come back when you are done.

The Vienna Coup:

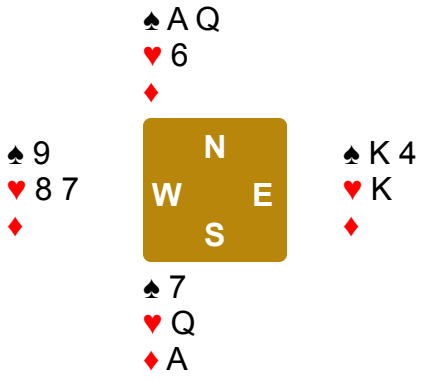
Nice name, huh?
Take a look at this ending, where South needs to win all four tricks. South is in her hand and can certainly win the three Aces. She has two Threats, the ♠Q and the ♥Q with which she hope to squeeze East.



South plays the ♦A and discards the ♥6 from dummy.

East will throw his ♥J because he can see that he must hold onto both ♠s.
Dummy's ♥A now drops the ♥K, and establishes South's ♥Q.
BUT SHE HAS NO ENTRY TO IT, SHE IS LOCKED IN DUMMY.

So, let us apply the Vienna Coup! At some earlier time, perhaps the first trick, or the fourth trick or whenever, dummy's ♥A was played. So the ending would now look like this:



South plays the ♦A and discards the ♥6 from dummy.

East is squeezed in ♥s and ♠s.
The difference here is that South no longer needs an extra entry to her ♥Q because she is already in her hand.

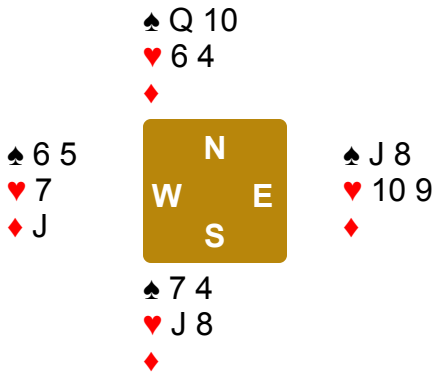
THE VIENNA COUP IS THE CASHING OF A HIGH CARD IN ONE HAND TO CREATE A THREAT IN THE OTHER HAND

Want to see the Vienna Coup in action?
Go to Deal 7, then come on back.

The Suicide Squeeze: (aka the Cannibal Squeeze)

This squeeze often occurs when the defenders have made a mistake, but there are some situations where they defend perfectly and still get caught in it. What happens is that one defender cashes a winner and in so doing squeezes his partner.

Look at this ending:



West cashes the ♦J.

Discard the ♥4 from dummy and the ♠4 from your hand. East is squeezed and you win the last three tricks.

If West had just ignored the ♦ winner and led one of the other suits East would have been assured of taking 2 tricks.

There is just one Suicide Squeeze Deal presented in this set so I won't identify it for you, just be on the lookout.

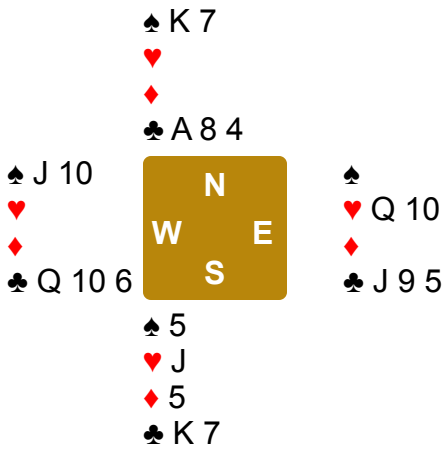
The Double Squeeze:

Usually you think of a squeeze occuring when one defender is trying to guard two suits. In these descriptions we have often said "East is squeezed in ♠s and ♥s." But sometimes when you are trying to set up a squeeze on one player it will turn out that West guards one suit but East guards the other suit. So you try to get a situation where neither one can guard a THIRD suit.

That sounds messier than it should. Suppose you have a long ♦ suit which you play to use for a squeeze. It turns out that West guards a ♠ threat while East guards a ♥ threat.

You will say to yourself: "West guards the spades, East guards the hearts, nobody can guard the clubs."

Here is how it works:



You play your ♦5.

West is not squeezed, but he must keep both ♠s to guard against dummy so he is forced to discard a ♣. Since you know your ♠7 cannot win a trick now you throw it. East is not squeezed, he can spare the ♥10.

But you then play a ♠ to dummy's ♠K. This squeezes East who now has the sole guard for both ♥s and ♣s. He will probably throw his ♣5 in which case you take the last 3 ♣ tricks.

Deal 13 is a good example of a Double Squeeze.

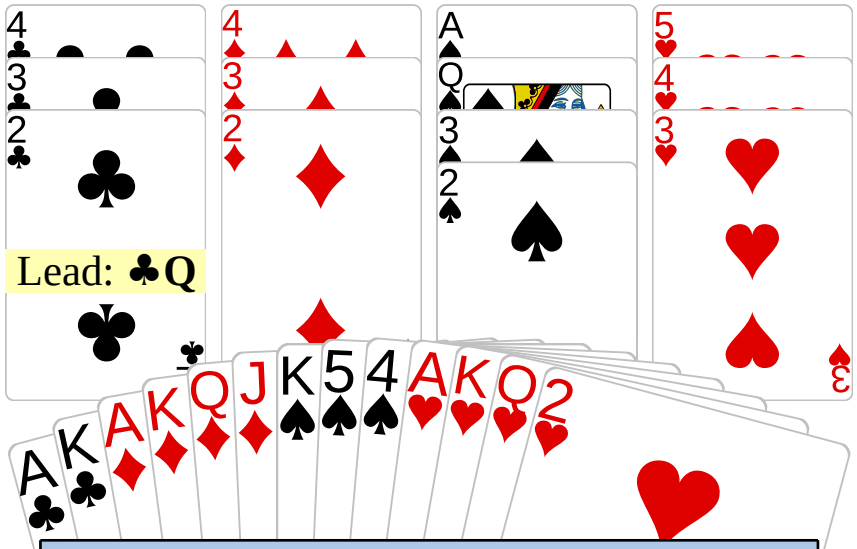
That's all folks:

I didn't start this lesson by talking about how difficult Squeeze Plays are. As you have seen, though, they do require some effort, both learning how to execute them and in the execution itself. Most of the examples here are classified as Simple Squeezes. There is another whole level.

If your interest is piqued you might want to look for the Vise Squeeze, or perhaps the Winkle and the Stepping-Stone squeeze. How about the Trump Squeeze or the Criss-cross squeeze?

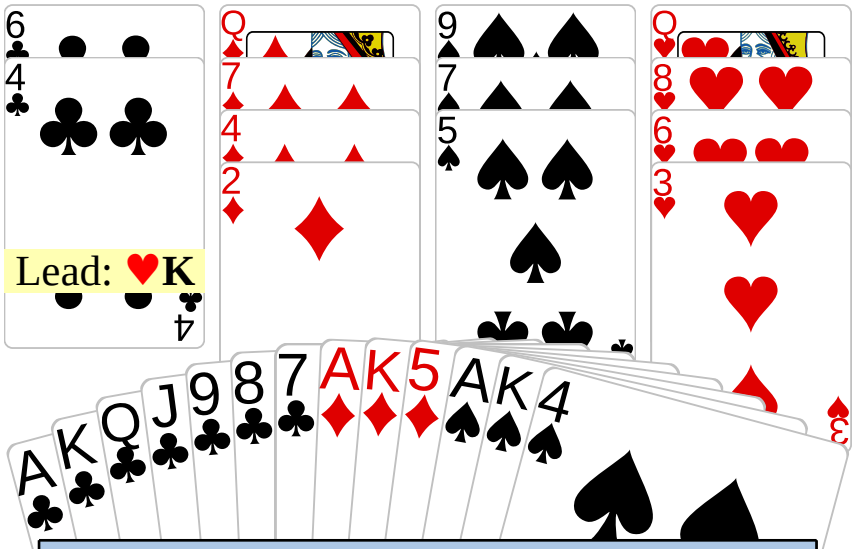
Good luck.

Deal 1 Ctr: **7NT** Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 2 Ctr: **7♣** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 3 Ctr: **6NT** Goal: at least _____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 4 Ctr: **6NT** Goal: at least _____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 5 Ctr: **6NT** Goal: at least _____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total

Decide How to Develop Winners			
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 7NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣Q

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 7♣
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥K

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♣K

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 6NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠K

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥K

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ K 5 4 ♥ A K Q 2 ♦ A K Q J ♣ A K	
♠ J 10 9 8 ♥ J 10 9 8 ♦ 10 9 ♣ 10 6 5	N W E S	♠ 7 6 ♥ 7 6 ♦ 8 7 6 5 ♣ Q J 9 8 7
	♠ A Q 3 2 ♥ 5 4 3 ♦ 4 3 2 ♣ 4 3 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2♣	Pass	2♦
Pass	3♦	Pass	3♠
Pass	4NT[1]	Pass	5♦[2]
Pass	7NT		
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace

7NT by North
Lead: ♣Q

Never mind the bidding. North is to play 7NT. East leads the ♣Q.

You have 12 top tricks. There are no finesses available, but a 3-3 split in either Major suit will provide the 13th trick. As you can see, this is not going to happen.

But there is another possibility; if the same defender holds 4 ♥s and 4 ♠s you will be able to squeeze him in those two suits.

You win the ♣K and play ♥ A K Q to test the ♥ suit, but East discards a ♣ on the ♥Q. (You tested ♥s first because of dummy's limited entries to the ♠ suit.)

Your ♥2 is not a winner but is a **THREAT** to become one. West holds the ♥J which is a **GUARD** against that happening.

Next play your 4 ♦ winners, discarding a ♣ from dummy. West follows twice, then starts to feel the pressure. He cannot discard the ♥J because it is guarding your ♥2, and since he can see those 4 ♠s in dummy he doesn't want to discard a ♠. He discards both his ♣s, trusting East to guard that suit.

Now you play the ♣A. At this point you are still hoping the ♠s will split 3-3. They aren't going to, as you see, but something wonderful happens instead. West cannot discard his ♥J because to do so would establish your ♥2. So he must throw a ♠ instead. You realize your ♥2 is not a winner so you just play ♠K, ♠A and ♠Q, and amazingly dummy's ♠3 has become your thirteenth trick.

Of course if West had discarded his ♥J you would have cashed your ♥2 and then taken three ♠ winners.

You just executed a Squeeze Play and you didn't even have to try.

This type of squeeze is called an ***automatic squeeze*** because it operates equally well against either defender. Suppose the EW hands were switched. Of course the opening lead would have been different, but when you were ready to play your ninth winner the hands would have looked like this.

This time it is East who holds the only Guards in both ♠s and ♥s.

You play the ♣A and he must give up one of those Guards.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

♠ Q J 10 3
♥ J 9 7 5 4
♦ 8 6
♣ 5 2

♠ 9 7 5
♥ Q 8 6 3
♦ Q 7 4 2
♣ 6 4



♠ A K 4
♥ —
♦ A K 5
♣ A K Q J 9 8 7

♠ 8 6 2
♥ A K 10 2
♦ J 10 9 3
♣ 10 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2♣	Pass
2♦	Pass	3♣	Pass
3♥	Pass	4NT[1]	Pass
5♣[2]	Pass	7♣	
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 0 or 4 aces

7♣ by East
Lead: ♥K

East is to play 7♣. South leads the ♥K.

East is to play 7♣. South leads the ♥K.

You have 11 sure winners in your hand and dummy's ♦Q makes 12. Your main hope is for a 3-3 ♦ split in which case dummy's fourth ♦ will be a winner.

But there is another possibility in case the ♦s don't split. Dummy's ♥Q is a THREAT card which is GUARDED only by South's ♥A. If it is South who has the 4 ♦s you will be able to squeeze him.

You ruff the ♥K and play 5 more ♣ winners, being careful not to discard a ♦ or the ♥Q from dummy.

With everybody down to 7 cards this is the position. North's hand is important only in that he must hold on to his ♠ stopper. South must keep the ♥A and all four ♦s.

Play the ♠ A K and South begins to feel the heat.

On the ♠K you discarded dummy's small ♥ and South also discarded a ♥.

The ♣A is the SQUEEZE card. South absolutely cannot throw away his ♥A, so he discards a ♦ instead.

Since he still has the ♥A you know dummy's ♥Q is useless, so you discard it; North throws the ♥9. Dummy's fourth ♦ has become a winner.

This type of squeeze is called a ***positional squeeze*** because it only operates against one of the defenders. Suppose the EW hands were switched as shown below. When you were ready to play the Squeeze Card the hands would have looked like this.

North holds the only Guards in both red suits, but he cannot be squeezed.

You must play from dummy **BEFORE** North plays, so he just matches whatever you do.

If you discard the ♥Q North will throw his ♥A. If you discard dummy's fourth ♦, North will throw his fourth ♦.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ A K 7 3 ♥ Q 9 3 ♦ A 6 5 ♣ A 8 6	
♠ 9 5 ♥ 10 7 5 2 ♦ 10 3 ♣ K Q J 4 2	N W E S	♠ J 10 6 2 ♥ 8 4 ♦ J 9 8 4 ♣ 9 7 3
	♠ Q 8 4 ♥ A K J 6 ♦ K Q 7 2 ♣ 10 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	6NT		
All Pass			

6NT by South
Lead: ♣K

South is to play 6NT. West leads the ♣K.

You have 11 winners, 3 ♠s, 4 ♥s, 3 ♦s and 1 ♣. If either ♠s or ♦s split 3-3 that would give you your 12th trick. If both split 3-3 you can make all thirteen tricks.

As you see, neither of them splits. However since one defender, East in this case, holds both Guards you should be able to squeeze him.

Visualize what would happen, though, if you win the first trick and then play your 4 ♥ winners. East would play his 3 ♣s and 2 ♥s on those 5 tricks and he would not be squeezed. The problem is that you have to **RECTIFY THE COUNT**.

To rectify the count you have to lose all the tricks you can afford to lose, which in this hand is exactly one trick. So you duck the ♣K and win the next trick

when West continues with the ♣Q.

AHA! The count is rectified, so now you play your ♥ winners.

East has no problems on the first 3, he just plays his 2 ♥s and 1 ♣.

Here is the situation.

West follows.

The Squeeze Card is the ♥A.

You toss dummy's last small ♣ and East will have to decide whether it is better for him to throw a ♠ or a ♦. He doesn't know that discarding either one is going to hand you the contract, so he will probably discard a ♦.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ K Q 10 ♥ Q J 9 8 5 2 ♦ 10 3 ♣ 9 5	
♠ A J 3 ♥ 7 6 4 ♦ K J 6 ♣ A Q 10 7	N W E S	♠ 7 4 2 ♥ A K 3 ♦ A Q 7 4 ♣ K J 3
	♠ 9 8 6 5 ♥ 10 ♦ 9 8 5 2 ♣ 8 6 4 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	2♥	6NT	
All Pass			

6NT by West
Lead: ♠K

West is to play 6NT. North leads the ♠K, dummy plays the ♠2 and South the ♠5.

You have 11 winners; 1 ♠, 2 ♥s, 4 ♦s and 4 ♣s. If you can make a trick with the ♠J all will be well. But if not, as long as North holds the ♠Q, which is almost a certainty, you will be able to squeeze him in ♠s and ♥s.

The first thing you should do is to duck the ♠K. If North foolishly plays another ♠ your troubles are over. But he doesn't, he plays the ♥Q instead which you win with dummy's ♥K.

Even though North didn't play a second ♠ your first round duck served a very important purpose - it rectified the count for your squeeze.

Next play off your 4 ♦ winners, discarding a small ♥ from your hand.

You are now zeroing in on North.

Play the ♣K, ♣J, then over to your ♣Q.

Here is the layout after the 3 ♣ plays. Everybody followed suit except North who discarded a ♥ (unhappily, it seemed).

North discards the ♥9.

When you play your ♣A, discarding a ♠ from dummy, North is squeezed.

If he discards the ♠10, then his ♠Q will fall underneath your ♠A, establishing your ♠J.

But if he instead throws the ♥9, both of dummy's ♥s will become winners.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 7 5 2 ♥ A 10 8 ♦ A 9 3 ♣ A Q 8 2	
♠ J 9 4 3 ♥ 5 ♦ 8 6 5 2 ♣ J 10 9 4	N W E S	♠ 10 8 ♥ K Q J 9 6 3 ♦ 10 4 ♣ 7 6 3
	♠ A K Q 6 ♥ 7 4 2 ♦ K Q J 7 ♣ K 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♣	2♥	Dbl
Pass	2NT	Pass	6NT
All Pass			

6NT by North
Lead: ♥K

North is to play 6NT. East leads the ♥K, dummy plays the ♥2 and West the ♥5.

As usual, you have 11 winners; 3 ♠s, 1 ♥, 4 ♦s and 3 ♣s. If ♠s split 3-3 dummy's ♠6 will become trick #12. If ♠s don't split though, you will have the chance of a squeeze if the defender with long ♠s also has 4 or more ♣s.

For a squeeze to operate you will need to lose one trick and the time to do that is right now. Let East hold the ♥K and win his ♥ continuation with your ♥A.

West discarded a ♦ on the second ♥.

You might as well find out about the ♠s right now. Play the ♠ A K Q.

Too bad, East discards a ♥ on the third round of ♠s.

West now holds the the only guard in ♠s.

Play the ♦A, then ♦ K Q.

West will follow to all three ♦s.

Now for the squeeze.

West discards.

Play dummy's ♦J and discard your last small ♥.

If West discards the ♠J you will cash dummy's ♠6, then win the last 3 ♣ tricks.

So West will no doubt throw a ♣ instead. In which case you win the last 4 ♣ tricks.

Squeezes are so very satisfying.